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FISHING AND THE COLONIAL ECONOMY: THE CASE OF MALAWI

BY JOHN MCCRACKEN

NO ONE who has ever made the dusty, two-hour drive from Zomba in the cool Shire Highlands to humid, low-lying Mangochi (Fort Johnston) can be unaware of the importance of fishing in Malawi.¹ Along the road, streams of traders, their bicycles loaded with fish baskets, make their way up the escarpment to the markets of Zomba and Blantyre. Lorries pass, also loaded with fish, on the drive to Blantyre or perhaps to far-flung markets in Zambia and Zimbabwe. In the villages bordering Lake Malombe and Lake Malawi thousands of fish – *chambo*, *utaka*, *matemba* and *usipa* – dry on wooden trestles or are smoked over slow-burning fires. On Lake Malawi seine nets (*khoka*) are manoeuvred into place by fishermen in dugout canoes, while here and there on open beaches groups of men and boys can be seen hauling their nets to the shore.

Yet for all the conspicuous visibility of fishing, its role in the colonial economy of Malawi has been very largely ignored by historians preoccupied with developments in the agricultural sector, in particular the fate of the three major export crops, cotton, tobacco and tea.² Research has been conducted by biologists into the breeding habits of Malawi fish and the productivity of particular lagoons.³ An impressive interdisciplinary programme mounted at the University of Malawi from the late 1960s came up with a wealth of information concerning the ecology of Lake Chilwa, perhaps the most productive source of fish in the country.⁴ In recent years, sociology under-

¹ This article was originally presented to the Colloquium on the Exploitation of Animals in Africa, held at the University of Aberdeen on 23–24 March 1987. I am grateful to my wife, Juliet Clough, for her assistance; her articles on Lake Malawi and on canoe-building in *Malawi International*, *Focus on Malawi*, etc. are not only more readable but also more accurate and informative than many academic papers.

² See, for example → Robin Palmer, 'The Nyasaland tea industry in the era of international tea restrictions, 1933–1950', *J. Afr. Hist.*, xxvi (1985), 215–3 → Elias Mandala, 'Peasant cotton agriculture, gender and inter-generational relationships: the lower Tchiri (Shire) valley of Malawi, 1906–1940', *African Studies Review*, xxv, ii–iii (1982), 27–44; John McCracken, 'Planters, peasants and the colonial state: the impact of the Native Tobacco Board in the Central Province of Malawi', *J. Southern African Studies*, ix (1983), 172–92.

Aspects of the fish trade in Northern Rhodesia are discussed in W. V. Brelsford, *Fishermen of the Bangweulu Swamps* (Livingstone, 1946), and Ian Cunnison, *The Luapula Peoples of Northern Rhodesia* (Manchester, 1959), 6–16; see also Hugh Fearn, *An African Economy: A Study of the Economic Development of the Nyanza Province of Kenya, 1903–1953* (London, 1961), 214–20.

³ See, for example, C. J. Shepherd (ed.), *Investigation into Fish Productivity in a Shallow Freshwater Lagoon in Malawi 1975/1976*, sponsored by the Ministry of Overseas Development (London, 1977?)

⁴ Margaret Kalk, A. J. McLachlan, C. Howard-Williams (ed.), *Lake Chilwa: Studies of Change in a Tropical Ecosystem* (The Hague, 1979); Margaret Kalk (ed.), *Decline and Recovery of a Lake* (Zomba, 1970).

graduates have studied contemporary patterns of fishing.⁵ But these accounts, while valuable in themselves, are written under the common misconception that the commercialisation of fishing derives only from the late 1950s and that, previously, fishing was a subsistence activity unrelated to the spread of capitalism and essentially unchanged over hundreds of years. There is no recognition of the major impact of European fisheries or of the lengthy antecedents of fish-trading, an activity occupying 'not less than 10,000' people in 1931, according to the census of that year.⁶ Only in the excellent regional studies of Mandala and Vaughan is adequate attention given to the role of fishing in the domestic economy, and their accounts tend to concentrate on fishing in the late nineteenth century at the expense of later developments.⁷

This paper seeks to provide an introduction to the evolution of fishing and fish-trading, focusing in particular on the south end of Lake Nyasa (present-day Lake Malawi), the main source of fish in Nyasaland during the colonial period. Discussions of economic change in twentieth-century Africa have frequently been influenced by variants of the development-of-underdevelopment thesis with its emphasis on the transforming and impoverishing role of the international capitalist economy. In this paper, however, I follow Mandala in arguing that 'ecological change was almost as important as capitalism in the social transformation of the region'.⁸ Changes in the levels of Lake Malawi and the Shire River constantly interacted with changes in transport and market opportunities to influence the position of fishing within the wider economy of the area.

The Natural Environment

With over one-fifth of its surface under water, Malawi possesses a greater range of fishing-grounds than almost any other landlocked country in Africa. By far the most important is Lake Malawi, the third largest lake in Africa, 350 miles long and just over 50 miles wide at its broadest. Areas of greatest depth occur in the northern portion which is bordered by steep, rocky shores; further south the lake is comparatively shallow and fringed by low-lying land consisting of sandy beaches alternating with areas of water-weed and swamp. It is this contrast in environment that explains why the fishing grounds in the south are so much richer than those further north. In the northern portion, plant nutrients are limited by the absence of oxygen at the deeper levels of the lake, but in the south a mixing of nutrients and oxygen occurs throughout the water, making this an area of high productivity. Shoals of fish

⁵ Lonely Kapeleta, 'The coming of the Tonga and the commercialisation of fishing in Monkey Bay area: a case study', Sociology Seminar Paper, Chancellor College, University of Malawi, 1980; Charles Ralph Kafumba-Utonga, 'Fishing on Likoma Island: change and development', Chancellor College Seminar Paper, University of Malawi, 1981.

⁶ Nyasaland Protectorate Report of the Census for 1931, Malawi National Archives, Zomba (MNA), 51/1307/30.

⁷ Elias Coutinho Mandala, 'Capitalism, ecology and society: the lower Tchiri (Shire) valley of Malawi, 1860-1960' (Ph.D., University of Minnesota, 1983); Megan Vaughan, 'Social and economic change in Southern Malawi: a study of rural communities in the Shire Highlands and upper Shire valley from the mid-nineteenth century to 1915' (Ph.D., University of London, 1981).

⁸ Mandala, 'Capitalism, ecology and society', 261.

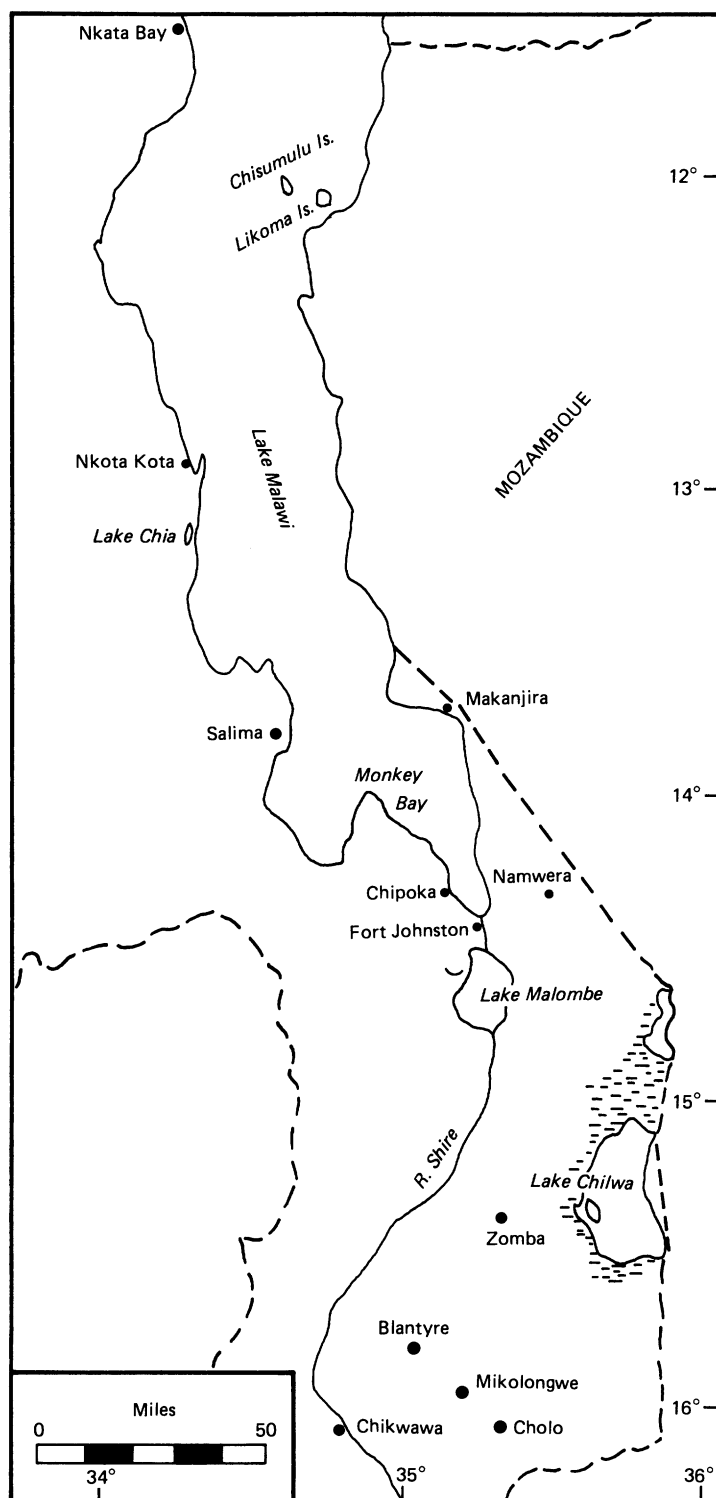


Fig. 1. Part of central and southern Malawi.

congregate in the breeding season along the gentle slopes of the southern beaches which make excellent sites for on-shore fishing, unlike the rocky scarps of the north.⁹

Nearly 500 species of fish are believed to exist in Lake Malawi, the great majority belonging to the cichlid family, many being unique to the lake, some of them to just a few hundred yards of shoreline. Five species are particularly important for fishermen, the first being *chambo* (*Tilapia*), the most abundant fish in the shallow southern waters, easily caught, easily cured and excellent, tasty eating. On rocky shores where the bottom slopes away steeply, *utaka* (*Haplochromis*) are caught in substantial numbers, while at the mouths of rivers congregate the salmon-like *mpasa* (*Barilius microlepis*), according to Livingstone 'a splendid fish and the best we have eaten in Africa'.¹⁰ The tiny *usipa* (*Engraulicypris sardella*), similar to whitebait, is highly valued both as food and bait, and there is also a market for the catfish, *kampango* (*Bargus meridionalis*) which makes very good eating when smoked.

Until recently, fishing techniques were largely influenced by the character of the local environment. At the north end of the lake and around Likoma and Chizumulu islands where the shores are rocky and steep, fishermen made use of two types of net: the *chilimira*, an open water seine net worked from two canoes, and the *matchela*, a gill net, usually left in the water overnight. On the south-east arm of the lake, however, and on the south-west arm as far north as Salima, the existence of gently sloping sandy beaches made possible the use of *makoka*, large meshed seine nets varying in length from 50 to 400 yards, which were manoeuvred into place by fishermen in a single canoe and then pulled to the beach by ropes. At the outlet to the Shire river (the only outlet from the lake) a combination of fish weirs, traps and baskets were used to catch such fish as the *mpasa* running downstream to spawn, while in the highly productive Chia lagoon fish traps were used along with basket traps and spears. All over the lake, dugout canoes provided the essential means of transport, those in the south with a triangular interior, those in the north more circular with a narrow slit at the top. Canoes were normally hollowed out of the much-prized *chonya* tree (*Bretonadia microcephala*) or else from the *msangu*, which lasted less long being a softer wood, but was quicker and easier to make. Nets were constructed of local fibres (*bwazi* or *chopa*), and were much admired for their strength and lightness by early European observers.¹¹

Over the last century, variations in the level of Lake Malawi, the Shire

⁹ See C. K. Ricardo Bertram, H. J. Borley and Ethelwynn Trewavas, *Report on the Fish and Fisheries of Lake Nyasa* (London, 1942). I have also made use of an unpublished manuscript by Jenny Carter on the game-parks of Malawi.

¹⁰ David and Charles Livingstone, *Narrative of an Expedition to the Zambesi and its Tributaries* (London, 1865), 374.

¹¹ William Percival Johnson, *Nyasa the Great Water* (Oxford, 1922), 59. Useful late nineteenth-century accounts of fishing include: Livingstone, *Narrative*, 374–6; Reginald Foskett (ed.), *The Zambesi Journal of Letters of Dr John Kirk*, II (Edinburgh, 1965), 369, 371; Horace Waller (ed.), *The Last Journals of David Livingstone*, I (London, 1874), 91, 95–6; J. F. Elton, *Travels and Researches among the Lakes and Mountains of Eastern and Central Africa* (London, 1879), 289, 293; Henry Faulkner, *Elephant Haunts* (London, 1968), 124. For more recent surveys see: Ricardo Bertram, Borley and Trewavas, *Report*, 65–74; M. C. Hoole, 'Notes on fishing and allied industries as practised among the Tonga of the West Nyasa district', *Nyasaland J.*, VIII (1955), 25–38; Kapeleta, 'Coming of the Tonga'; Kafumba-Utonga, 'Fishing on Likoma Island'.

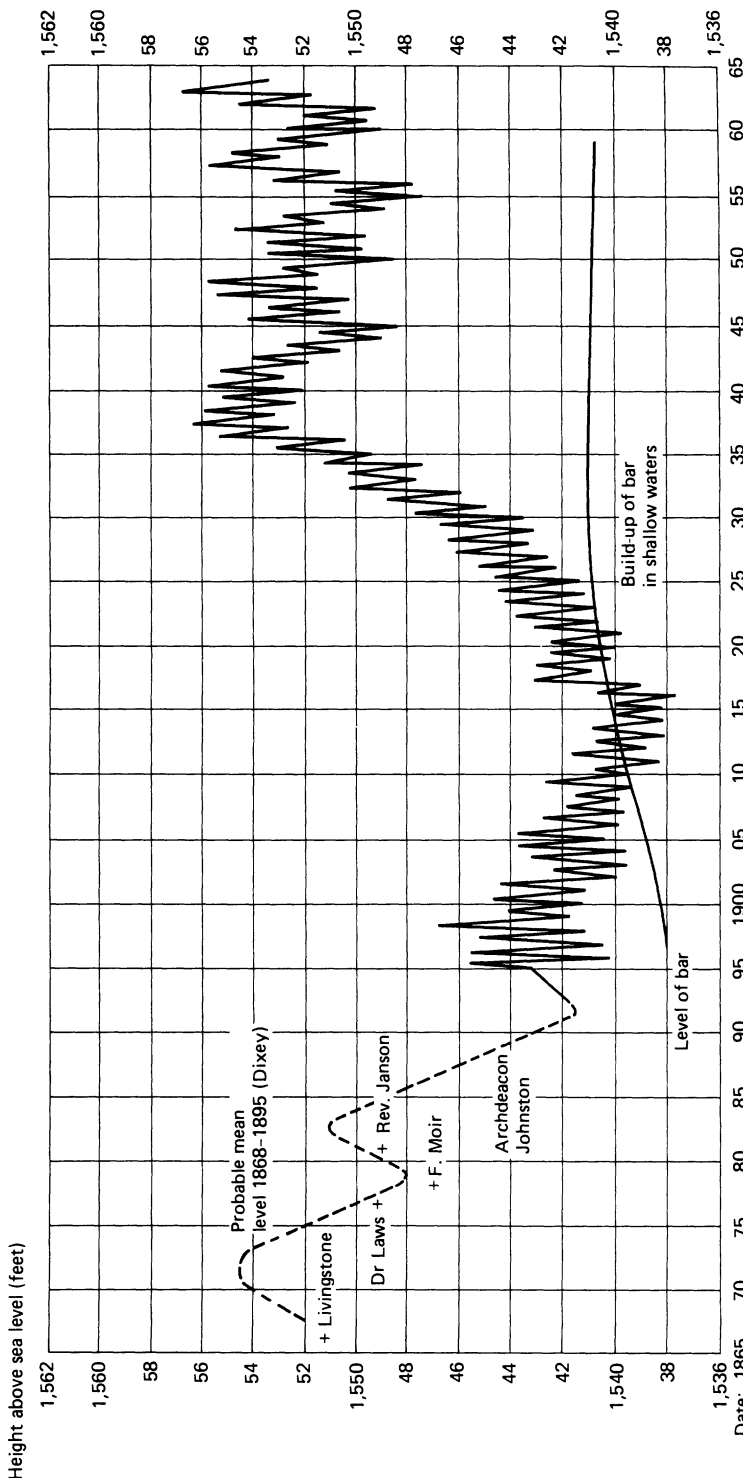


Fig. 2. Level of Lake Malawi 1895-1963. From J. G. Pike, 'The hydrology of Lake Malawi', *Society of Malawi Journal*, xxi, 2 (1968).

River and Lake Chilwa have profoundly influenced economic activities on their shores. All are subject to annual variations of water level of about four feet between the dry and wet seasons. But they have also been subject to substantial changes in the mean annual water level over lengthy periods as is demonstrated in fig. 2.¹² Starting in the 1870s when the Shire River/Lake Malawi route was still regarded as a major highway into Central Africa, the average water level in Lake Malawi gradually fell up to 1895. It recovered temporarily in the next few years, and then fell again to reach its lowest known level in 1915, by which time Fort Johnston had become virtually unusable as a port and a sand bar had formed, barring access to the Shire River and bringing its flow almost to a halt in all but the rainy season. Lake levels then gradually rose, covering reefs, washing away sandspits and inundating fertile rice fields south of Makanjira on the south-east arm of the lake. Initially, the rise in the level of the lake had no effect on the upper Shire River, where water levels fell so low by 1924 that Lake Malombe dried up almost entirely, with food gardens being planted in large numbers on its bed.¹³ But in the decade after 1927 the level of the river at Fort Johnston rose by about a foot each year, sweeping away the sand bar and dislodging mounds of *sudd*, or weeds, in 1934, bringing down the bridge at Liwonde in 1936 and permanently engulfing thousands of acres of floodland in the remote Lower Shire district.¹⁴ Meanwhile the water level of Lake Chilwa fluctuated in an even more dramatic manner. A shallow, saline expanse of water, covering some 800 square miles but nowhere more than ten feet deep, Lake Chilwa virtually dried up on four occasions during the colonial period, the first in 1900 when it was noted that 'there was no water at all between Chisi [Island] and the mainland; nothing but black mud dried and cracked by the heat and littered with millions of univalvular shells'.¹⁵ Further low levels were reported in 1914–16, 1920–2 and in 1934, resulting on each occasion in a heavy mortality among fish stocks, with the survivors taking refuge in the surrounding swamps and lagoons to re-emerge a couple of years later when the lake returned to its normal size.¹⁶

The Origins of African Commercial Fishing

During the late nineteenth century, fishing played an important role in the economy of the Mang'anja people living at the south end of Lake Malawi

¹² The literature on the changing water levels of Lake Malawi is extensive. Among the most useful studies are: Robert Crossley, 'High levels of Lake Malawi', University of Malawi Staff Seminar paper no. 2, 1980; J. G. Pike and G. T. Rimmington, *Malawi: a Geographical Study* (Oxford, 1965), 114–18; J. G. Pike, 'The movement of water in Lake Nyasa', *Nyasaland J.*, x (1957).

¹³ South Nyasa District Annual Report for 1931, MNA NSF 4/1/3.

¹⁴ Southern Province Annual Report for 1936, MNA NS 3/1/6; Mandala, 'Capitalism, ecology and society', 190–91.

¹⁵ H. L. Duff, *Nyasaland under the Foreign Office* (London, 1903), 111.

¹⁶ See N. Lancaster, 'The changes in the Lake level', in Kalk, McLachlan and Howard-Williams, *Lake Chilwa*, 43–4.

¹⁷ This account is drawn largely from Vaughan, 'Social and economic change in Southern Malawi', 40–60. See also Megan Vaughan, 'Food production and family labour in Southern Malawi: the Shire highlands and the upper Shire valley in the early colonial period', *J. Afr. Hist.*, xxiii, iii (1982), 351–7, and Zomba History Project texts, University of Malawi, Chancellor College Library, especially Nyanja, Yao and Lomwe Testimonies, collected by Megan Vaughan.

and on the upper Shire River.¹⁷ Agricultural production was household-based and involved the planting of a variety of crops – sorghum, millet, groundnuts, cassava and maize. Labour was also devoted to a number of non-agricultural activities, among them salt-production, cotton-weaving and fishing. Fishing was a gender-specific activity, monopolised almost entirely by men who made use of kinship ties in order to mobilise labour. Communal tasks such as setting nets, hauling them to shore and constructing canoes were normally performed by the male members of an *mbumba* or matrilineage group, though fish trapping could be undertaken individually. Some attempts were made by Yao chiefs who had gained political dominance over the area from the early 1860s to exert ritual control over fishing activities. But because most Yao refrained from participating directly in fishing, concentrating instead on long-distance trade, this had little effect on the organisation of the industry. The right to fish does not appear to have been restricted to particular groups, though Livingstone in 1861 found evidence of private fishing grounds on the west side of the lake under the control of a single proprietor.¹⁸ Most fish caught were consumed within the fishermen's *mbumba*, but there was also an active trade to the more agriculturally productive highland regions adjacent to the lake involving the exchange of dried fish for maize and beans.¹⁹ Most fishing was conducted in the warmer months of the year (between October and March) with the colder months, when the fish retreated to the centre of the lake, being reserved for net-making and canoe-building. For most people, however, fishing was not a full time activity; when the rains started, men joined women in working their gardens.²⁰

The establishment of colonial rule had little immediate effect on patterns of fishing. Other non-agricultural activities – notably the production of iron and cotton – suffered from the competition of cheap, mass-produced imports. But these did not affect the sale of fish which continued to be exchanged for foodstuffs in the highlands well into the 1920s. Some labour previously employed in fishing may have been diverted into cotton-growing which the Government actively encouraged in the upper Shire Valley from 1903.²¹ By the First World War, however, cotton cultivation was in decline, though it revived again in the early 1920s when the drying up of Lake Malombe made it possible for cultivators to plant their food gardens on the floor of the lake while growing cotton on its edges. In 1925, 315,613 lbs of cotton (a record) was produced in the South Nyasa District.²² No attempt to regulate fishing or to stimulate its growth was forthcoming from the government, though in 1907, after repeated failures, it did succeed in introducing brown trout from Britain to the Mulunguzi River on Zomba Plateau, thus providing European officials with some healthy sport – a striking illustration of its development priorities.²³

The growth of fish trading from Lake Malawi to Blantyre and Zomba had

¹⁸ Livingstone, *Narrative*, 380.

¹⁹ Vaughan, 'Social and economic change in Southern Malawi', 219.

²⁰ Ricardo Bertram, Borley and Trewavas, *Report*, 80.

²¹ Vaughan, 'Food production', 361–64.

²² South Nyasa District Annual Report for 1931, MNA NSF 4/1/3.

²³ Department of Agriculture, in letters to J. McClounie, Head of the Scientific Department, 1898–1901, MNA 1/3/1; Charles Seed, 'Trout in Nyasaland', *Nyasaland J*, II, ii (1949), 23–4.

its origins in the impact of the First World War. Up to then, any fish sold in Zomba came from Lake Chilwa less than twenty miles away.²⁴ Between 1913 and 1915, however, the lake almost completely dried up, bringing fishing to a temporary halt.²⁵ At the same time, the market for foodstuffs enormously increased following the arrival of thousands of Imperial and South African troops who were stationed in military camps at Blantyre and Zomba before being shipped up Lake Malawi to Tanganyika as reinforcements for General Northey's army.²⁶

At Fort Johnston the enterprising headman, Mwamadi Matewere, took advantage of the new market by erecting a reed barrier with fish traps across the Shire River at the Bar in 1917.²⁷ Around the same year, traders began making the 80 to 120-mile journey to the Shire Highlands markets where dried fish was sold at a price 300 per cent higher than could be obtained on the lake. By 1922 officials were publicly noting that 'There is a large fishing industry at the south end of the lake' servicing the requirements of Blantyre and Zomba.²⁸ No strong prospects for this industry were held out by the Government which continued to put its faith in the cultivation of cotton. In 1925, however, Lake Malombe was flooded as a result of a combination of exceptionally heavy rainfall and a rise in water levels. With their food gardens inundated, cultivators who had been attracted to the lake 'were forced' (so the local district officer reported) 'to try and find room for their maize gardens in the limited space between the Lake edge and the hills... This naturally gave a severe shock to cotton production'.²⁹ Output fell to a low of 3,601 lbs. in 1928 and many peasants switched their attention to fishing or fish trading as a means of obtaining the money required both to purchase maize from the hills and to pay their hut tax. By 1931 at least 10,000 people were involved in the trade, the great majority being hawkers carrying dried fish on long poles slung over their shoulders or, less frequently, travelling on bicycles.³⁰ Most fishermen remained near to subsistence, utilising family labour and achieving average earnings of no more than £10 a year. But some fishermen at Nkota Kota made between £20 and £30, while Mwamadi Matewere made considerably more. By 1932 he had constructed a set of fish weirs round the Bar so impenetrable, according to the chief Game Warden, that 'it is literally impossible for any fish of even medium size to enter the Shire river at all'.³¹ Several Indian and European lorry-drivers purchased

²⁴ As early as 1888 the Blantyre missionaries recorded that 'caravans of fish from Lake Chilwa, bringing likewise crates of fowls, have supplied the children and the Europeans with food'. *Life and Work in British Central Africa*, August 1888, quoted in Vaughan, 'Social and economic change in Southern Malawi', 210.

²⁵ *Life and Work in British Central Africa*, July–December 1915, 6; Zomba History Project, Gravelo Njala interviewed by Megan Vaughan, 15 Sept. 1978.

²⁶ This is particularly vividly documented in *Life and Work in British Central Africa*, January–March 1917, April–December 1917, June–March 1918, July 1918–June 1919. For the impact of the war on Fort Johnston, see Cleo J. C. Malambo, 'Aspects of the socio-economic history of Mangochi township in the colonial period', History Seminar Paper, Chancellor College, University of Malawi, 1984/85.

²⁷ C. B. Nichols to Attorney-General, 6 January 1930, MNA S1/1437i/30.

²⁸ S. S. Murray, *A Handbook of Nyasaland* (London 1922), 110; Norman H. Pollock, *Nyasaland and Northern Rhodesia: Corridor to the North*, (Pittsburgh, 1971), 304.

²⁹ South Nyasa District Annual Report for 1931, MNA NSF 4/1/3.

³⁰ Nyasaland Protectorate Report of the Census for 1931, MNA S1/1307/30.

³¹ Minute by R. C. Wood, 26 April 1930, MNA S1/437i/30.

fish directly from him at a rate of up to 2,000 a day. Some of these provided loans in advance for the construction of additional fences.³²

The Greek Connection

The 1930s marked a transformation both in the organisation of commercial fishing on Lake Malawi and in government attitudes towards it. Up to then, fishing and fish-trading had been almost entirely African activities; but with the advent of the motor lorry, European and Indian middlemen began purchasing fresh fish at the lake shore for sale in Blantyre and Zomba. This was followed in 1930 by the appearance of the first European fisherman, a Mr Liegl, who made himself deeply unpopular locally by erecting his fish traps some fifty yards on the lakeward side of Matewere's barrier.³³ Fishing Rules were introduced in 1931, preventing non-Africans from fishing for trade within two miles of the mouth of the Shire River without permission from the Provincial Commissioner.³⁴ But this modest attempt to control European fishing was effectively nullified in 1934 by Nicholas Yiannakis and his two brothers Christos and Stavros who started fishing commercially at Chipoka, near the present site of Maldeco Fisheries, some twelve miles from Fort Johnston.

The Yiannakis brothers were recent immigrants from the Greek island of Limnos, attracted to Nyasaland by the prospects of tobacco growing in the Namwera district inland from the lake. They worked for a while in the transport business before deciding to utilise their boyhood skills by becoming commercial fishermen.³⁵ Their first step was to purchase three seine nets of European manufacture, 670 yards long, 23 feet wide and capable of netting a 500 yard front to a distance of nearly half a mile into the lake. In 1938 they began trawling on a small scale, using a boat with an outboard motor; and they also owned four lorries which were employed in transporting fresh fish from the lake to Blantyre and dried fish to Salisbury and beyond.³⁶ Their annual catches increased from 56 short tons (74,700 fish) in 1937 to 509 short tons (679,200 fish) in 1939 and then to 622 short tons in 1943 and 770 in 1944. In 1940 they employed 150 permanent workers and were the only firm operating fulltime on the lake, though a number of licences had been granted to other non-Africans, including Nicholas Tratoris, one of the pioneer Greek

³² District Commissioner Fort Johnston to Provincial Commissioner Southern Province, 14 November, 1932, MNA S1/437i/30.

³³ C. B. Nicholls to Attorney-General, 6 January 1930; P. C. Southern Province to D. C. Fort Johnston, 17 June 1930, MNA S1/437i/30.

³⁴ D.C. Fort Johnston to P.C. Southern Province, 16 March 1931, MNA S1/437i/30. S1/437i/30.

³⁵ There is a brief introductory note on the origins of the Greek community in Malawi in D. Brian Roy, *The Malawi Collection* (Blantyre, 1985). See also Mangochi (Fort Johnston) District Book, vol. v, 1933-7; Dr Lamborn to Mr Tucker, 23 October 1935, MNA S1/1437i/30.

By the 1940s the Luapula fish industry in Northern Rhodesia 'was run mainly by a community of Greeks who themselves started life as fishermen on the island of Rhodes' (Cunnison, *Luapula Peoples*, 9).

³⁶ Lamborn to Tucker, as cited in n. 35. Ricardo Bertram, Borley and Trewavas, *Report*, 76-77; South Nyasa District Annual Report for 1940; Cecil Barker to P.C. Southern Province, 6 August 1936, MNA S1/1437i/30.

settlers in Nyasaland, H. M. Rodrigues and the Indian trader, Ibrahim Osman.³⁷

The success of the Yiannakis brothers was to prove inimitable. Few fundamental innovations in the basic pattern of fishing were involved; like their African rivals, the Greeks relied heavily up to the 1940s on shore-based fishing, using large nets dragged to the beach. The durability of their European-manufactured nets was considerably greater than that of the home-made products used by Africans, however, and they had the crucial advantage of being able to transport fresh fish by lorry direct to market, whereas African traders were forced to sell their fish to middlemen for smoking. Where they gained over their European rivals was in their mastery of the varied skills required in running the business effectively. Experienced fishermen, unlike virtually any other Europeans who sought to break into the industry, they were also shrewd entrepreneurs with a sensitive feel for market opportunity. Much of the fish they sold on the domestic market went to African traders either at the lake or at various lorry stops prior to arrival at the firm's Blantyre depot – an indication of their awareness of the need to work with the 'bicycle boys' rather than to compete directly against them. They were also pioneers in exploiting the export market in dried fish to Salisbury, a market which consumed nearly 60 per cent of their catch in 1939.³⁸

At a time of expanding markets, the rise of the Greeks did not entail any diminution in African commercial fishing. Certainly, Mwamadi Matewere was almost literally swept away in the rising waters of the lake which carried off his weirs and traps in 1936 and rendered this type of fishing virtually unworkable.³⁹ But as the shoreline became flooded and once fertile gardens were inundated, fishing became an ever more important part of the economy of lakeside peoples, indeed virtually the only source of cash open to them other than migrant labour. Fish trading too became an increasingly popular option, attracting thousands of people to the lakeshore from up to a hundred miles away: many of these had been driven out of cash crop farming by the low prices prevalent during the 1930s' depression. Most of these newcomers used bicycles whose relative cheapness, carrying capacity and mobility were of crucial importance in extending sales of fish beyond the main lorry arteries into the southern Malawian hinterland. 'Of all African industries, the fish trade is the one that has made most progress in recent years', the Provincial Commissioner reported in 1939, adding that 'the fish carrier's bicycle is familiar to both sight and smell on every road' in the province.⁴⁰ Between 1935 and 1939 the number of bicycles annually imported through Chikwawa increased from 93 to 3,970.⁴¹ Cycle repair shops sprang up at every district centre. An enterprising entrepreneur at Zomba began renting bicycles to traders charging 6d. per round trip to Lake Malawi plus one fish out of every 200 carried.⁴² In the South Nyasa District alone, 1,001 full time African

³⁷ Mangochi (Fort Johnston) District Book, vol. VI, 1938–42, 'Fishing Permits'.

³⁸ Ricardo Bertram, Borley and Trewavas, *Report*, 76–7.

³⁹ Cecil Barker, D.C. Fort Johnston to P.C. Southern Province, 6 August 1936, MNA S1/1437i/30.

⁴⁰ Southern Province Annual Report for 1939, MNA NS 3/1/8.

⁴¹ *Ibid.*

⁴² *Ibid.*, and Southern Province Annual Report for 1933 MNA NS 3/1/3.

fishermen were registered in 1938 along with 898 professional fish carriers and 396 professional makers of string, rope, nets and floats. A total of 516 shore seine nets and 112 float nets were recorded in the district along with 51 scoop nets and 1,943 fish baskets.⁴³

Government Intervention

For the colonial government, the success of Yiannakis Brothers came both as a threat and a challenge. Up to the 1940s the State had normally intervened on the side of European planters when their interests clashed with those of African peasants.⁴⁴ But, in the case of fishing, the policy was reversed. During the 1920s, officials reached the comfortable conclusion that no European fishing enterprise on Lake Nyasa was likely to be commercially successful and that, as far as the African industry was concerned, 'no interference, official or otherwise, could be of any benefit to the native, who makes his own string, his nets and his canoes and his basket traps...[and who] puts out his nets when the Lake allows him to do so'.⁴⁵ With the advent of the Greeks, however, the issue was raised again. Senior officials might support British planters, physical embodiments of the Empire, whose value to the State was as much political as economic, but they felt little sympathy for Greeks, non-Anglo-Saxon, non-Protestant and not even English-speaking. District officers sided with local chiefs in arguing that to allow Europeans to engage in commercial fishing would be to undermine the only money-making activity existing near the lake and hence increase the number of tax defaulters.⁴⁶ There were allegations – later rebutted – that irreparable damage to fish stocks would be caused by European methods of fishing and claims that disputes between European and African fishermen might lead to a breakdown of social control.⁴⁷ But while Secretariat officials sympathised with such views, they refused to restrict the industry to Africans by legislation on the grounds that to do so would be to make the Government vulnerable to settler demands that tobacco growing should be made a European monopoly.⁴⁸ From 1937, Fishing Rules, making it obligatory for European fishermen to obtain permits, were extended to cover Lake Malombe and the whole of the southern arms of Lake Nyasa, and the Governor agreed to restrict the issue of further permits until the results of a Fisheries survey were known. There

⁴³ South Nyasa District Annual Report for 1938, MNA NSF 4/1/5. These figures should not be accepted uncritically. In 1933 the District Commissioner came up with figures of 2,480 fishermen and 674 fish curers in the South Nyasa District. (Annual Report for 1933, MNA NSF 4/1/4.)

⁴⁴ See John McCracken, 'Peasants, planters and the colonial state: the case of Malawi, 1905–1940', *J. Eastern African Research and Development*, xii (1986). → Robin Palmer, 'White farmers in Malawi: before and after the Depression', *African Affairs*, LXXXIV (1985), 211–45.

⁴⁵ Dr Cuthbert Christie, British Museum Nyasa Expedition, to Chief Secretary, Zomba, 10 November 1925, MNA S1/1470/25. See also P.C. Northern Province to Chief Secretary, 23 January, 1926, *ibid*.

⁴⁶ Minutes to Baraza held at Fort Johnston, 17 February 1933; D.C. Fort Johnston to P.C. Southern Province, 17 February 1933, MNA S1/437i/30.

⁴⁷ Senior P.C. Zomba to D.C. Fort Johnston, 17 January 1930; D.C. Fort Johnston to Chief Secretary, 24 August 1938, MNA S1/437i/30.

⁴⁸ Minutes 14 and 20 December 1932, *ibid*.

was no general prohibition of non-African fishing, however, which continued to expand on the south-east arm of the Lake.⁴⁹ In 1944, Yiannakis Bros. took 770 tons of fish, Trateris and Matsikas took 112 and Ibrahim Osman took 135.⁵⁰

During the 1940s the debate intensified. Wartime restrictions on the import of rubber resulted in an acute shortage of bicycle tyres and in turn to a fall in the number of traders.⁵¹ Fishermen were no longer able to unpick old tyres to make their nets, a practice that had developed in the 1930s and there was a disturbing decline in average yields which reached a low point in 1947 when Yiannakis Brothers reported that their catches were the worst they had known.⁵²

With unease growing as to the long-term viability of the industry, demands for government intervention came from a variety of quarters. Official concern with the nutritional requirements of the working classes surfaced in Britain in the aftermath of the First World War and was extended to the dependent colonial empire in the late 1930s.⁵³ Nyasaland was chosen in 1938 as the site for an ambitious interdisciplinary survey, headed by Professor B. S. Platt, Director of the Human Nutritional Research Unit of the Medical Research Council, and including among its members a team of experts recruited to survey the fish resources of the Lake. Their report, while dispelling fears that fish stocks were being eroded, increased the pressure for intervention through its emphasis on the crucial importance of fish as the sole major source of animal protein in a country woefully lacking in meat.⁵⁴ For a few years in the early 1940s, Platt's Nutrition Unit experimented in a number of intermediate techniques – machines for spinning rope and twine, plank-built boats, advanced methods of smoking fish. The results were disappointing. In every case the new techniques proved demonstrably less effective than those already routinely employed by Lake Nyasa fishermen.⁵⁵

By this time, however, the owners of the Shire Highlands tea estates were beginning to look for government support in meeting the nutritional requirements of their workers. Under the *thangata* system, widely employed in the Shire Highlands up to the 1940s, African tenants on European estates functioned as sharecroppers, growing much of the food consumed by their families on the land allotted to them. In 1946, however, the government introduced a major programme of land purchase aimed at converting sharecroppers either into independent peasants on Crown Land or else into full-time workers. By 1953, over 321,000 acres had been excised from the European estates. On the European-owned land that remained, employers

⁴⁹ D.C. Fort Johnston to P.C. Southern Province, 12 May 1937, *ibid.*; Mangochi (Fort Johnston) District Book Vol. VI.

⁵⁰ South Nyasa District Annual Report for 1944, MNA NSF 4/1/6.

⁵¹ South Nyasa District Annual Reports for 1943 and 1944.

⁵² Southern Province Annual Report for 1947, MNA NS 3/1/16.

⁵³ Circular letter by J. H. Thomas, Secretary of State for the Colonies, 18 April 1936; *Report on Nutritional Research in the Colonial Empire*, (London, 1938), MNA S1/138/36.

⁵⁴ B. S. Platt, 'Report on a nutrition survey in Nyasaland', duplicated [1940?], MNA Library Q. 267.

⁵⁵ Quarterly reports on the work of the Nutrition Unit, to 30 September 1940; 31 December 1940; 30 June 1941; Memo on 'Continuation of Fishery Work' by H. B. H. Borley, MNA NCK 3/6/2.

were starting to take a more active interest in the proper feeding of their labour.⁵⁶

The subsequent demand that regular supplies of cheap dried fish should be made available to estates in the main tea-growing areas of Cholo and Mlanje brought the government and the estate owners into sharp conflict with the European fisheries, notably Yiannakis Bros. As good businessmen, the brothers looked to expand the Rhodesian market which was larger and more profitable than the decentralised and irregular markets provided by the Nyasaland estates. This policy ran counter to the Nyasaland government's strategy of ensuring that adequate food supplies were available to meet local demands. The issue came to a head in 1949 when Nyasaland was confronted by a major famine precipitated by the failure of the rains. Official instructions that no fish should be exported were circumvented on a technicality by Yiannakis Bros who annoyed the authorities still further in 1950 by seeking to export additional quantities of fish in defiance of government policy.⁵⁷ As distrust deepened, colonial officers criticised the Greeks in increasingly outspoken language. 'We are all too aware that there is a market in this Protectorate for all fish that is available and marketable, but the truth of the matter is, no doubt, that Messrs Yiannakis and their fishing friends do not choose to find those local markets as the export trade to Southern Rhodesia is too attractive' minuted one official.⁵⁸ 'As regards Yiannakis, Bodley has suggested that it might be sound policy to remove this firm from the fishing industry at the earliest convenient moment' added another, in a letter to Malcom Barrow, chairman of a committee appointed to investigate the future of the industry.⁵⁹ Barrow's committee refrained from recommending this extreme measure, though it did advise that no export of fish should be permitted until local requirements had been met, a suggestion that the government eagerly accepted.⁶⁰ Not until 1958, five years after the creation of the Federation of Rhodesia and Nyasaland, was the ban on exports to Salisbury lifted.⁶¹ Government price controls on fish (introduced in 1949) also continued, and efforts were made from 1953 to stimulate African commercial fishing through the provision of government loans.

The 1950s

Our main source on fishing in Malawi in the closing years of colonial rule is the report and evidence of the Commission of Enquiry set up to investigate

⁵⁶ An additional factor was the severe shortage of labour that hit Nyasaland tea estates in the 1940s and encouraged owners to make conditions more attractive. S → Robin Palmer, 'Working conditions and worker responses on Nyasaland tea estates, 1930-1953', *J. Afr. Hist.*, xxvii (1986), 116-18.

⁵⁷ 'Precis for Executive Council. Fish supplies and export', 9 December 1949, MNA 4-12-10F/3631315930.

⁵⁸ Minute by W.J.R.P., 17 February 1950, *ibid.*

⁵⁹ F. L. Brown to Hon. M. P. Barrow, 4 April 1950, *ibid.*

⁶⁰ Chief Secretary to Deputy Director of Agriculture, 15 May 1950, *ibid.*

⁶¹ H. B. H. Borley, 'Notes for working party on the development of the fishing industry', 1961, MNA 4-6-8F/4858/37031. The inherent profitability of the export market is revealed in the fact that when the ban was lifted, sales to Salisbury totalled £56,435 in 1960, about 25 per cent of the European firms' catch.

the industry in 1956, supplemented by the 'Jack Report' of 1958-9.⁶² In the previous year an estimated 7,705 short tons of fish were caught: 3,300 tons by African fishermen and 4,405 tons by three non-African firms. Of the fish caught by Africans, 700 tons were taken in the south-east arm of Lake Nyasa, 300 tons on the Salima lake shore at the south-west of the Lake and only 600 tons in Lake Chilwa, soon, in 1965, to become the largest fishery in the area. Virtually all fish caught by commercial firms were taken in the south-east arm of Lake Nyasa. *Chambo* (*Tilapia*) remained by far the most popular species caught, though *utaka*, *nchila* and *kampango* were all of importance. More than twice as much fish were caught in the warm months of the year (September to March) than in the cold season (April to August) when the shoals of *chambo* often remained in the deeper water near the centre of the lake. However, in January and February, Messrs Yiannakis deliberately reduced catches because of the difficulties involved in transporting fish to Blantyre on untarred roads during the wettest months of the year.

Despite government disapproval, Messrs Yiannakis continued to dominate commercial fishing, though it was now a one-man firm, owned by Christos who had bought out his two brothers for £30,000 in 1951 after a bitter family row.⁶³ A substantial part of his fishing was now conducted by trawling from motor boats, with as many as 23,769 dozen fish being caught in a single month. Despite the ban on sales to Rhodesia, he was still able to make a comfortable living, earning profits of £3,185 in 1954-5 after expenditure of £26,754 (11.8 per cent on turnover) and also making £3,609 from cattle sales, his bakery and canteen.⁶⁴ About a third of the catch was sold direct to traders at Chipoka with the remainder being boxed in ice and carried south in open lorries. Half of this (another third of the catch) was sold to 'boys on bicycles' along the route; half of the remainder went to traders at the Blantyre depot. Only when these demands had been satisfied did Yiannakis allow the residue to go to the Cholo estates.⁶⁵

Perhaps the most remarkable feature of African fishing was the emergence of a small group of 'big men', capitalist fishermen who employed labour on a regular basis and invested in imported nets and boats. By contrast to the situation in the 1920s, these were not usually local fishermen with political influence like Mwamali Matewere but rather migrant workers, 'African businessmen, some from other parts of the country... [who] have spent most of their lives in South Africa or Southern Rhodesia and have come back to set up businesses'.⁶⁶ Some of the problems they faced are illustrated in the evidence of Crispo Gwedala who began fishing on the south-east arm of the Lake in 1954 after a four-year spell in South Africa. Helped by a government loan of £25, he bought a canoe, a second-hand lorry and a nylon net, 900 yards long, with which he caught fish worth over £300 in a season. But as his business grew, his problems multiplied. His workers gave him increasing trouble: 'four times they stole my fish from me and sold it zig-zag fashion. I employed natives and these people did try to pull my neck stealing this and

⁶² 'Report of the Commission of Inquiry into the Fishing Industry', 1956, MNA COM 9/4/2; *Report of an Economic Survey of Nyasaland, 1958-1959* (Salisbury, 1959), 255-64.

⁶³ Evidence of Christos Yiannakis to the Commission of Inquiry, Blantyre, 17 July 1956, MNA COM 9/3/1.

⁶⁴ *Ibid.*

⁶⁵ Evidence of A. D. Sanson, Fisheries Officer, to the Commission of Inquiry, Fort Johnston, 8 June 1956, *ibid.*; 'Report of the Commission of Inquiry'.

⁶⁶ *Ibid.*

that'. His lorry overturned at Liwonde in January 1956. When it was involved in a further expensive accident in March he was almost ready to quit.⁶⁷

Yet if the risks were great, so were the opportunities. Men like Amos Charles who employed twenty workers, using shore seine nets at Nkota Kota and Lake Malombe, could catch up to 400 dozen fish at each casting.⁶⁸ At the south-east arm of Lake Nyasa, two African fishermen were taking 100 tons of fish apiece each year. For the fortunate or the wealthy, fish trading too could be a profitable venture. 'Some of the bigger African fish businessmen have got the idea of having agents along the road between here and Blantyre selling fish for them while they themselves proceed with the remainder of the fish to the towns', reported H. B. Chipembere, then a member of the Legislative Council, in 1956. He himself had every intention of entering the business.⁶⁹

In contrast to this small group, most fishermen remained part-time cultivators, drawing their labour from their matrilineage or *mbumba*, but among these too, changes were taking place. From the late 1950s, Tonga fishermen from Nkata Bay, many of them former labour migrants, began to settle in family groups along the south-east arm of the Lake, a much more productive area for fishing than their rocky northern homeland. Because they lacked access to land, they were much more intent on maximizing profits from fishing than were the local Mang'anja. Most made use of *chimilira* nets strung between two canoes, a new technique in this part of the Lake and one that allowed them to pursue shoals of fish into the deeper waters rather than awaiting their arrival near the shore. They also made organizational innovations, creating fishing companies made up of an owner and his *alovi* (workers), not all of whom were members of the owners' lineage. Under this system group ownership of equipment was abandoned and, instead, nets and boats became the private property of owners, most of whom left the day-to-day control of fishing to a son while they supervised the drying and selling of fish on shore. Tonga wives, lacking an agricultural role, often participated actively as fish traders while, during the fishing season, the men took up residence in temporary camps wherever fish were to be found. So successful did the operation prove that, by the end of the 1960s, many Mang'anja fishermen on the coast south of Monkey Bay had been forced back into farming, leaving fishing to the Tonga intruders.⁷⁰

The popularity of fish trading as an occupation in the Southern Province is a striking commentary on the low wages and poor conditions prevailing on settler estates. To ply his trade, Namango Nachuma from Chaoni village in the heart of the tea-growing Cholo District had to cycle for three days to the eastern shore of Lake Chilwa, evading the Portuguese police who had kidnapped several of his friends. At the lake he could wait for five days or more to fill his basket of 240 fish before spending a further four days making the laborious return journey to the market at Mikolongwe. He bought the

⁶⁷ Evidence of Crispo Gwedala to the Commission of Enquiry, Fort Johnston, 8–9 June, 1956, *ibid.*

⁶⁸ Evidence of Amos Charles, *ibid.*

⁶⁹ Evidence of H. B. Chipembere, *ibid.*

⁷⁰ Kapeleta, 'The coming of the Tonga and the commercialisation of fishing'. For related developments on Lake Chilwa see Pauline E. Phipps, 'The "Big" fishermen of lake Chilwa: a preliminary survey of entrepreneurs in a rural economy', in M. E. Page (ed.), 'Land and labor in rural Malawi', *Rural Africana*, xxi (1973).

fish for 3d. each and sold them for 4d or 5d. in the market, a paper profit of from £1 to £2 for a gruelling twelve day expedition, but one that does not take account of the cost of food, of tyres, which had to be replaced at least three times a year, or of his bicycle which lasted less than three years and cost £3 15s. when new.⁷¹ Given that the most energetic trader was unlikely to make more than two trips a month, Nachuma's maximum profit cannot have exceeded £30 a year. But this was better than the 30s. a month with rations paid as minimum wages on the Cholo estates, particularly as it allowed him an independence which wage labour denied. Traders selling fish from Lake Chilwa in Zomba market could make the journey in a day, a feature which encouraged some of the more ambitious to employ assistants at £1 10s. a month.⁷² Other traders making the lengthy journey from Lilongwe to the Yiannakis fisheries at Chipoko might have to wait up to three weeks before they filled their baskets and three weeks more to sell the fish in Lilongwe market.⁷³ By 1960, however, some African traders had begun to move their fish by lorry, often combining with other traders to hire a lorry for the transport of their individual consignments.⁷⁴

Conclusion

Until recently, it was generally accepted that 'the economic history of Malawi in the colonial period is the history of the creation of a labour reserve with the colonial state, despite occasional vacillations, ultimately serving the interests of Southern African capital'.⁷⁵ For the proponents of this view, the drain of migrant labour to the south transformed Nyasaland into a rural slum characterized, according to Martin Legassick, by 'rural underdevelopment, economic decay and pauperization'.⁷⁶ The evidence contained in this paper points to a rather different conclusion. Far from being destroyed by the corrosive impact of capitalism, the fishing industry in Malawi has expanded substantially during the twentieth century, though with the greatest advances taking place in the decades immediately after the period covered in this essay. In 1963, estimated landings of fish in Malawi were 15,100 short tons; by 1978 they had reached over 67,000 short tons.⁷⁷ Furthermore, the pattern of expansion bore little relation to underdevelopment stereotypes. Because both fish stocks and markets were under-exploited, the rise of commercial fisheries did not result in the fall of African fishermen. Migrant workers, rather than

⁷¹ Evidence of Namango Nacuma to Commission of Inquiry, Blantyre, 17-19 July 1956, MNA COM 9/3/1.

⁷² Evidence of Laison Grant Nkhawfi and Jonas Joseph Kajawo, Zomba, 17 May 1956, *ibid.*

⁷³ Evidence of Sanson, *ibid.*

⁷⁴ Borley, 'Notes for a working party'.

⁷⁵ Megan Vaughan, 'The politics of food supply: colonial Malawi in the 1940s', in Centre of African Studies, University of Edinburgh, *Malawi: an Alternative Pattern of Development* (Edinburgh, 1984), 70. Dr Vaughan questions the view expressed in this quotation.

⁷⁶ Martin Legassick, 'Gold, agriculture and secondary industry in South Africa, 1885-1970: from periphery to sub-metropole as a forced labour system', in Robin Palmer and Neil Parsons (eds.), *The Roots of Rural Poverty in Central and Southern Africa* (London, 1977), 175.

⁷⁷ Figures taken from Swanzie Agnew and Michael Stubbs (eds.), *Malawi in Maps* (London, 1972), 142 and from *The National Atlas of Malawi* (1985), 58.

being lost to the domestic economy, played an important role in the post-war development of the industry. The colonial government marginally supported African as opposed to non-African enterprise. Particularly striking was the relative lack of colonial intervention in fishing despite the fact that in other areas of the economy elaborate controls were constructed over marketing and production.⁷⁸ Pre-colonial rulers often associated themselves intimately with the fate of the fishing industry, preparing charms to ensure good yields and prohibiting fishing at certain times of the year.⁷⁹ By contrast, the colonial government, with only occasional deviations recognized that its ability to influence African fishing was negligible, and did almost nothing about it. nothing about it.

SUMMARY

Despite the evident importance of fishing in Malawi, its role in the territorial colonial economy has been largely ignored. This paper focuses on the evolution of fishing and fish-trading at the south end of Lake Nyasa (Lake Malawi), emphasising the interaction between ecological change and changes in market opportunity. During the late nineteenth century, fishing played an important role in the economy of the Mang'anja people alongside agricultural production. Communal tasks such as the setting of nets or building of canoes were conducted by male members of an *mbumba* or matrilineage group who traded fish with the agriculturally productive highland regions nearby in exchange for maize and beans. Little changed initially with the establishment of colonial rule, though some labour previously employed in fishing may have been diverted into cotton-growing which the Government encouraged in the Upper Shire Valley. The establishment of military camps during the First World War, combined with the sudden drying up of Lake Chilwa, the major source of fish in the Shire Highlands, created the opportunity for enterprising fishermen to start a regular trade in dried fish to Blantyre and Zomba from about 1917. This was stimulated in the 1920s by the steady rise of water levels on the Shire River which brought cotton production virtually to a halt making fishing an attractive alternative.

The advent in the 1930s of non-African commercial fishermen who used lorries to transport fresh fish to Blantyre and dried fish to Salisbury did not prevent a further expansion of African fishing and fish-trading, many of the traders using bicycles to extend their sales into the southern Malawian hinterland. Officials tended to side with African fishermen when their interests clashed with those of incomers, notably the Greek Yiannakis brothers. But they had little success in introducing new techniques to improve productivity and fell back in the 1950s on the prohibition of exports to the Rhodesias, a policy aimed at ensuring a regular supply of fish to workers on European estates within Malawi.

By the 1950s, European companies were recorded as being responsible for over half the fish caught in Malawi. African fishing had been affected by the emergence of a small group of capitalist entrepreneurs, most of them former labour migrants, who had invested their savings in imported nets and boats and employed labour on a regular basis. Mang'anja fishermen now faced competition from Tonga migrants using new technical and organisational methods. In contrast to under-development stereotypes, the indigenous industry continued to expand, with migrant workers playing an important role in the development of fishing.

⁷⁸ See Clement Ng'ong'ola, 'Malawi's agricultural economy and the evolution of legislations on the production and marketing of peasant economic crops' *J. Southern African Studies*, xii (1980), 240–62.

⁷⁹ Vaughan, 'Social and economic change in Southern Malawi', 56; D. R. Mackenzie, *The Spirit-Ridden Konde* (London, 1925), 142.